have walked from one to the other. The sea route too is unlikely since the mouths of the two rivers are very far apart. In any case, the river dolphins are not closely related to the salt-water dolphins of the Indian Ocean and must have evolved separately from them. One possibility, therefore, is that the shifting rivers allowed the dolphins to move from one river system to the other. Sadly, both sub-species are now under severe threat from pollution and the diversion of water into numerous irrigation projects. [21]

Standing on the banks of the Yamuna in Delhi, I ponder on the fate of a river killed by ill-advised civil engineering. Did the Harappans feel like this as they gazed on the dying Saraswati? The concern with water is echoed in the Vedas. The greatest feat of Indra, king of the gods, is to have defeated Vritra, a dragon, who had held back the river waters behind stone dams. Indra slays Vritra after a great battle, destroys the dams and sets the rivers free. It may be significant that the slaying of Vritra is specifically mentioned in a hymn eulogizing Saraswati. Perhaps the ancients too struggled with their inner demon—the suspicion that they may have somehow brought on their downfall by interfering with nature.

LAND OF THE SEVEN RIVERS

At the core of the Rig Vedic landscape was an area called Sapta-Sindhu (Land of the Seven Rivers). This is clearly the heartland of the Rig Veda, but the problem is that the text does not clearly specify the seven rivers. It is almost as if it was too obvious to be worthy of explanation. The hymns repeatedly describe the Saraswati as being ‘of seven-sisters’, so the sacred river was certainly one of the rivers, but the others are uncertain. The conventional view is that the seven rivers include the Saraswati, the five rivers of Punjab and the Indus. This would mean that the Sapta-Sindhu region included Haryana, all of Punjab (including Pakistani Punjab) and even parts of adjoining provinces. This is a very large area.

Having traversed much of this terrain and read and re-read the text, I have come to a somewhat different conclusion. The Vedas clearly mention a wider landscape watered by ‘thrice-seven’ rivers [22] . While one does not